

from western Europe between the late 11th and late 13th centuries. Although more lightly armoured than the Christian knights, forces led by Saladin, Kurdish ruler of Egypt and Syria, and Baybars, Mamluk sultan of Egypt, inflicted a number of defeats on crusaders' heavily-armoured bodies of knights. The Muslim forces' flexible tactics were based on rapid manoeuvres, such as hit-and-run attacks by light horsemen, and they closed in for hand-to-hand combat only once they had gained the upper hand.

THE RISE OF THE OTTOMANS

During the course of the 14th century, a band of Turkish warriors established themselves in Anatolia, at the heart of the old Byzantine Empire. Initially led by Sultan Osman, they became known as the Ottoman Turks. Their military successes soon carried them deep into southeastern Europe. Originally mounted bowmen, the Ottomans also proved to be exceptionally quick to learn to use newer military technologies, adding gunpowder weapons to their armoury during the 15th century. Unlike other Muslim armies of the time, they also made successful use of foot soldiers as well as



mounted troops. In 1453, the Ottoman sultan, Mehmed II, captured the Byzantine capital of Constantinople using cannon – a groundbreaking use of gunpowder weapons. The city went on to become the capital of the Ottoman Empire all the way until the early 20th century.

▲ ARAB CAVALRY

An 11th-century Byzantine illustration shows Arab mounted troops armed with spears. Their armour was usually mail, with distinctive pointed helmets and aventails, which protected the neck.

◀ THE BATTLE OF HATTIN

In 1187, Muslim forces led by Saladin encircled, and subsequently defeated, an army of crusader knights at Hattin in Palestine, as depicted in this 15th-century illustration.



KEY FIGURE

BAYEZID I

1360–1403

Bayezid I was sultan (leader) of the Ottoman Turks from 1389 to 1403. Through a series of aggressive campaigns, he extended Ottoman rule across the Balkans and threatened Hungary. European knights organized an army to counterattack on the Danube, but Bayezid's army slaughtered this multinational force at Nicopolis in 1396. However, he met his match in 1402, when his army faced the Tatar warlord Timur at the Battle of Ankara. The Ottomans were defeated and Bayezid was taken prisoner, later dying in captivity.



▲ Sultan Bayezid was known as “Yıldırım” – “the Thunderbolt” – because of his ruthless, decisive manner of waging war.